



Illustration: Shyam Shrivastava

# Pixel Palette

The Web offers digital artists myriad resources to innovate and to enhance their skills

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**D**uring the Renaissance period, artists such as Leonardo da Vinci attempted to observe, study, and recreate objects with a greater degree of realism than previously existed. Renaissance artists created lifelike images of people and animals, set against backdrops that presented the illusion of depth and distance—like in the famed *Mona Lisa*—by using certain stylised techniques.

Today, 21st century offerings such as Adobe Photoshop, Corel Painter, Adobe Illustrator, 3D Studio Max, Macromedia Freehand and SketchPro are helping artists go where the palette and brush weren't able to—achieve a greater degree of realism as well as manipulate the 'real'—through the medium of digital art.

The term 'digital art' is expansive—it can refer to purely computer-generated art or digital

image manipulation (synonymously used with terms such as 'retouching' or 'morphing') of images or scanned photographs created on vector-based programmes.

## The Medium Is The Message

As a medium, computer-generated art has, and continues to evolve with technological advances.

While traditional art was confined to the canvas or paper, computer art can exist in different forms, such as images, an animated sequence, video, website, installation or 'kitsch' art forms. Photo manipulation is another emerging area of expression for digital artists.

Today, most advertisement banners (vinyl), animated films, and SFX sequences also employ variants of the digital art form. Digital art is an integral part of desktop publishing—consider jacket-design for books and cover design and/or layout for magazines and other periodicals.

Many traditional artists view digital art as a poor substitute for 'real' art. But, as artist and assistant professor G V Sreekumar of the Industrial Design Centre (<http://www.idc.iitb.ac.in/>) at IIT-Bombay says, "The visual grammar of digital art is entirely different from traditional art forms. Artists shouldn't try and recreate the

## Web Resources

GFX Artists: [www.gfxartist.com](http://www.gfxartist.com)  
 CG Talk: [www.cgtalk.com](http://www.cgtalk.com)  
 Sijun: [www.sijun.com](http://www.sijun.com)  
 Surf Union: [www.surfunion.com](http://www.surfunion.com)  
 CG Tantra (Indian CG Community): [www.cgtantra.com](http://www.cgtantra.com)  
 Furiae: [www.furiae.com](http://www.furiae.com)  
 Deviant Art: [www.deviantart.com](http://www.deviantart.com)  
 Digital Art Museum: [www.dam.org](http://www.dam.org)  
 ARS Electronica: [www.aec.at/en/index.asp](http://www.aec.at/en/index.asp)  
 Rhizome: [www.rhizome.org](http://www.rhizome.org)  
 Leonardo Electronic Almanac: <http://mitpress2.mit.edu/e-journals/LEA/>